

Recovering word-prosody in an extinct language family

The case for stress accent in Luwic

Oscar Billing

How to recover the prosody of extinct languages only attested in writing? Other phonological features, such as the articulation of consonants and the timbre of vowels, are often reconstructed using various approaches (e.g., loan words surveys). The same can hardly be said for prosodic features such as stress, pitch, and tone. In this talk, it is shown how typology, along with indirect evidence from segmental phonology, can be used to reconstruct word-prosody. The exemplify this process, a typologically informed reconstruction of stress accent in the Luwic languages is presented (Billing 2025).

The Luwic languages constitute a subclade of the Anatolian branch of the Indo-European language family. Prominent members of the clade include Luwian, Lycian, Lydian, and Carian (Billing & Elgh, *forthc.*). Notably, every Luwic language is recorded in a different writing system. Moreover, there is substantial variation in how some of the writing systems encode speech. For example, Luwian is attested in syllabic cuneiform and hieroglyphic scripts, while Lycian is only written using an autochthonous alphabetic script. Accordingly, the prosodic heuristics differ for each language.

Languages are typically divided into three broad categories with regard to word-prosodic typology: “stress accent” (SA), “pitch accent” (PA), and “tone”. Sufficiently clear definitions of SA and tone can be found in the typological literature: SA languages exhibit prominence on one syllable of the phonological word (Hayes 1995: 24–26), while in tone languages each syllable/mora is assigned a certain pitch level and/or contour (Hyman 2006: 229f.). Conversely, PA is an “intermediate” category, exhibiting diagnostic features of both SA and tone languages to varying degrees. Hyman (2009: 217f.) provides a “prototype definition” of SA, i.e., a cluster of properties found in the “clearest” case of the category normally understood as SA. Languages typically categorised as SA languages (e.g., English), exhibit many of these properties, while so-called tone languages (e.g., Mandarin Chinese) do not. By comparing the SA prototype to the features discernible in the philological data, the word-prosodic typology of the Luwic languages may be determined. If the Luwic languages are SA languages, we expect them to exhibit a large number of prototypical SA features. Conversely, if they are tone or PA languages, we expect the opposite situation. Helpfully, many of Hyman’s properties are phonetic rather than phonological (e.g., articulatory strengthening in stressed syllables, weakening of unstressed syllables) and segmental phonetics are more easily identified in the philological data.

In this talk, it is demonstrated that all Luwic languages attest to at least one prototypical SA property, usually more. Indeed, evidence is found for most diagnostic properties in at least one Luwic language. Therefore, I submit that all Luwic languages, as well as their most recent common ancestor (Proto-Luwic), belong to a SA typological profile with regard to word-prosody.

Bibliography

Billing, Oscar (2025). *Luwic Stress. A Comparative Study on Luwian, Lycian, and Lydian Word Accent*. PhD dissertation (Uppsala Universitet).

Billing, Oscar & Erik Elgh (forthcoming). Computational Anatolian phylogenetics using Maximum Parsimony. *Diachronica*.

Hayes, Bruce (1995). *Metrical Stress Theory. Principles and Case Studies*. Chicago/London: The University of Chicago Press.

Hyman, Larry M. (2006). Word-prosodic typology. *Phonology* 23, 225–257.

Hyman, Larry M. (2009). How (not) to do phonological typology: the case of pitch-accent. *Language Sciences* 31, 213–238.